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INNOVATION

UX Design For Mental Health: A Path To Better Workplace Well-Being

By Tina Gada, Former Forbes Councils Member.
for Forbes Technology Council, COUNCIL POST | Membership (fee-based)

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In today's fast-paced, digitally connected world, work has become more than just a place to earn a living. It's an environment where employees spend a significant portion of their time, and for many, the workplace is a source of fulfillment, identity and community.

However, as workplace demands grow and expectations rise, mental health challenges among employees are becoming more prominent. The World Health Organization even has its own set of guidelines on mental health at work. From stress and anxiety to burnout and depression, mental health issues are real, and they impact both the well-being of employees and the overall success of an organization.

But how can UX design play a role in alleviating these challenges and promoting a healthier mental environment at work?

Key UX Design Strategies To Support Mental Health At Work

1. Minimizing Cognitive Load: Keeping Things Simple And Accessible

One of the primary causes of stress at work is information overload. Whether it's an email inbox full of unread messages or a dashboard overloaded with unnecessary data, cognitive

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it easy for employees to find what they need quickly.

By designing digital tools that allow employees to focus on their tasks without getting distracted by unnecessary elements, companies can help reduce mental strain.

2. Encouraging Breaks And Relaxation: Wellness Tools At Hand

Another key strategy is encouraging employees to take breaks and look after their mental well-being throughout the workday. UX can be designed to remind employees to step away from their screens and engage in activities that rejuvenate their minds and bodies.

Best Practices:

• **Break Reminders:** Push notifications or gentle reminders prompting users to take a quick break or engage in a mindfulness exercise.

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• **Integrated Wellness Features:** Include tools that guide users through relaxation exercises, such as deep breathing, meditation or even quick stretching routines.

• **Customizable Timeouts:** Allow users to set their own break schedules and preferences, creating a personalized approach to well-being.

An employee, for example, could use a digital platform that sends them periodic reminders to breathe and stretch during their workday, helping them manage their stress levels.

3. Creating A Positive And Supportive Environment: Calming Design Choices

The design of digital tools should reflect the emotional environment a company wants to foster. Colors, typography and the tone of language used within the interface all play a role in the overall emotional impact. A calm, soothing interface can help reduce anxiety, while a busy or chaotic design can exacerbate stress.

Best Practices:

• **Soothing Colors And Fonts:** Use cool tones like blues and greens, which are known for their calming effects, and choose fonts that are easy to read.

• **Gentle Language:** Instead of using harsh or pressure-filled language in task instructions,

use encouraging and positive messaging.

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• **Social Interaction Spaces:** Build features that allow employees to connect with their colleagues for non-work-related conversations, such as casual chat rooms or virtual “water coolers.”

• **Peer Support Channels:** Provide platforms where employees can share experiences and support each other in a non-judgmental, confidential space.

• **Mental Health Resources:** Integrate quick access to counseling or mental health resources, ensuring employees know where to turn when they need help.

Employees can find comfort in joining a support group within their company’s platform, where they can share their experiences with colleagues who are going through similar challenges. This sense of belonging can help them feel less isolated and more supported.

The Impact: Mental Health And UX

By incorporating the principles of simplicity, wellness, positive reinforcement and social connection into the workplace tools employees use every day, companies can create a healthier, more productive work environment where employees are empowered to care for both their work and their mental health.

UX design isn’t just about functionality—it’s about creating an experience that supports and nurtures employees. By prioritizing mental health in UX design, companies can foster

a culture of well-being that not only benefits employees but also drives greater success and productivity in the workplace.

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Are One-Person AI Companies Coming?

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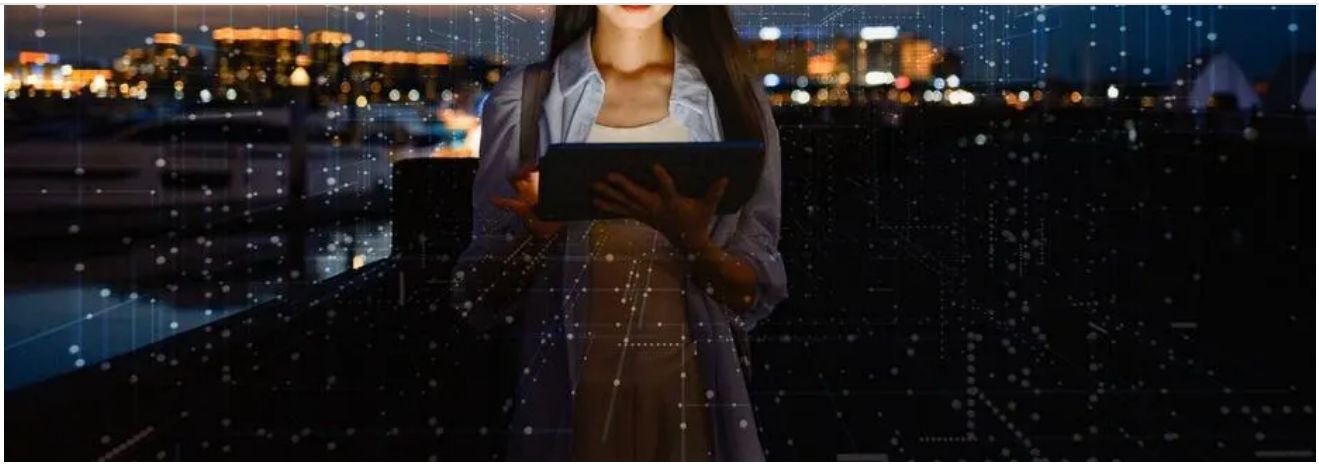

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Ten years ago, starting a business meant lawyers, accountants, office leases and months of paperwork before you ever served a single customer. That world is disappearing, and AI is about to finish what the internet started.

We're entering an era where a single person with domain expertise and access to AI tools can build and run a real company—not a side hustle, but an actual company.

AI doesn't need to be the best. It needs to be good enough.

There's a common objection: AI can't match a specialist. And that's true. It won't outperform a seasoned CFO or a tax attorney who's spent 20 years in the weeds. However,

I believe that misses the point. Most founders don't need the best; they need competent guidance across a dozen areas where they currently have none.

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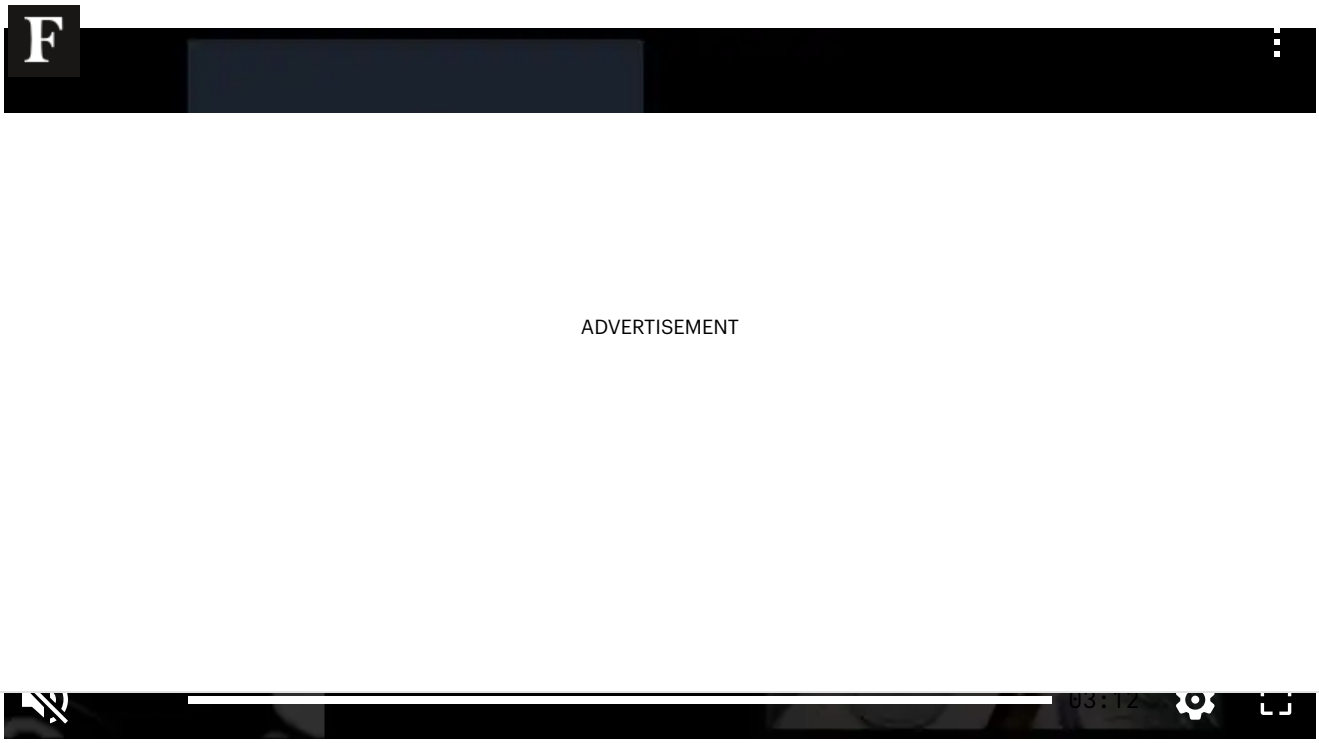
being squeezed out aren't mid-career professionals with mortgages and risk aversion; they're 23-year-olds who don't have much to lose. When the traditional path narrows, starting something of your own stops looking like a gamble and starts looking like the obvious move.

The infrastructure already exists.

The boring but critical barriers to starting a business have been quietly demolished over the past decade. You can form an LLC online before lunch, get your EIN from the IRS by early afternoon, open a business bank account by dinner and connect a payment processor before bed. Each of those steps used to take weeks of waiting, follow-up calls and physical paperwork. Now it can be a single day.

On the distribution side, marketplaces like Etsy, Shopify, Gumroad and Whop have made it possible to reach buyers without building an audience from scratch. These platforms handle discovery, payments and, in many cases, fulfillment. The solopreneur doesn't need to solve distribution when it's already solved.



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Regulation is an accelerant, not a brake.

Here's a point that often gets overlooked: Government regulation around employment, including payroll taxes, benefits mandates and compliance requirements, has made hiring genuinely expensive and bureaucratically exhausting. For a one-person company, every new hire is a major decision with real overhead.

AI flips that calculus. Instead of hiring an assistant, bookkeeper or social media manager, a solo founder can now automate parts of those functions at significantly lower cost and with far less administrative overhead. In practice, this can make technology a more attractive first step before employees are ever brought on.

Here's what this actually looks like.

The one-person AI company won't look like a miniature version of a traditional firm. It will look like a specialist, someone who's genuinely great at one thing, surrounded by AI handling everything else. It will be the designer, for example, who ships product, runs marketing, manages finances and handles customer support, not because they learned all of it, but because the tools got smart enough to help carry the load.

For traditional organizations, one-person AI companies represent a structural shift. As AI

reduces the need for labor, scale alone stops being a durable advantage. An increasingly common move to consider is pairing high-agency operators with intelligent tools and

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and technology executives. Do I qualify?

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